

CDN Incident Alert: 0091. TLP: CLEAR			Date
Title	MD	REST Media–Rybar Link: Coordinated Pro-Kremlin Network Targeting Moldova	23/09/2025

Summary

- REST Media’s newly created domain (restmedia.io) and associated social media assets (@RESTinvestigate on X and restinvestigate on Telegram) are disseminating anti-EU and anti-Moldovan government narratives; technical forensics link REST Media to the Russian pro-Kremlin Rybar network.
- EU blackmail, PAS/Sandu power grab, censorship, and Western interference framed as undermining Moldova's sovereignty.
- Content about Moldova achieved 3.1 million views, primarily from TikTok, and 469,000 reactions (Aug–early Sep 2025); on X, four posts alone exceeded 700,000 views; Telegram served mainly as an archive, but REST was systematically promoted by the large pro-Kremlin Infodefense network; additional amplification observed via the Pravda network and pro-Kremlin influencers.
- Preserve/triage evidence; alert platforms and regulators; geo-limit or remove coordinated assets; notify Moldovan authorities and EU bodies of election-risk; monitor/flag amplifiers (Pravda ecosystem, linked Telegram/X accounts); strengthen platform enforcement against covert influence.

Incident

On June 20, the domain restmedia.io was registered via Sarek Oy for 1337 Services LLC (Njalla), fronted by Cloudflare; on June 24, the operators launched an X account (@RESTinvestigate) and a Telegram channel (restinvestigate). Target audiences include Moldovan readers and Telegram users in Eastern Europe; the aim appears to be to erode trust in Moldova’s pro-EU leadership and institutions.

Despite Cloudflare masking, network reconnaissance identified the origin server as 217.16.19.189 within VK Cloud Solutions’ 217.16.16.0/20 range (a Moscow-linked hosting address). Co-location indicators show 217.16.21.112 hosts map.rybar.ru. Rybar is a prominent pro-Kremlin military analysis channel, which, according to the US State Department, receives [funding](#) Rostec. Both REST and Rybar assets use aaPanel, and both expose identical Pure-FTPd greeting configurations—consistent with shared templates or coordinated management across VK divisions.

Digital forensics reveals direct content-production integration: multiple images on restmedia.io contain EXIF filepaths “C:\Rybar на C\REST\...”, plus creator usernames “Makc,2” and “horom”; a video (“vonlaayen3.mp4”) shared on the REST Telegram channel also exposes these handles. This constitutes concrete evidence that REST content is produced within a Rybar-linked workflow.

Website taxonomy and slugs exhibit Cyrillic homoglyphs (“Es” instead of “c”) and asset labels in Russian, indicating a non-native (Cyrillic-locale) operating environment. Time-stamp clusters (+03:00) across dozens of branded images show asset creation on April 11—months before launch—suggesting planned, Russia-based production.

A narrative analysis of REST’s Moldova section (19 tagged articles) reveals consistent themes: EU leverage through conditionality; PAS's “institutional takeover”; “censorship” via media code and c-FIMI measures; Western/Polish “soft intervention” in security/elections; governance failure and social harms.

Amplification follows a hub-and-spoke model: TikTok drives almost all reach (3.11M views vs. ~2.3k on Telegram), with repeated reposting and boosting; the Pravda site-network and pro-Kremlin influencers on X and Telegram further extend distribution.

Systemic violation assessment

I. Why it’s a risk: Undermines democratic processes and institutional trust in Moldova (sovereignty, election

integrity, independent media).

II. Why it's manipulation: Covert infrastructure (Njalla/Cloudflare/VK Cloud), content laundering, cross-property misdirection, and inauthentic site amplification combine with distortive framing.

III. Potential illegality: Possible breaches may include sanctions evasion, as one of Rybar's creators is sanctioned. Additionally, deceptive practices and platform ToS violations (coordinated inauthentic behaviour, manipulation of engagement) may apply. National laws may apply to deceptive media and election interference analogues; DSA Articles 34–35 risk-mitigation duties could possibly be engaged for platforms. A formal legal review is necessary to assess illegality.

Narrative

Meta narratives: Western leverage and domestic capture erode Moldova's sovereignty and democracy.

Sub-narratives: EU funds "enslave" Chişinău; PAS "takes over" institutions; the media code/counter-FIMI measures are forms of "censorship"; Western/Polish "soft intervention" in elections and security; PAS tenure linked to social harm.

Impact

Reach: Around 3.11M TikTok views; 469,000 reactions; 700,000 X views (from four posts alone); 2,340 Telegram views (Aug–early Sep 2025). Additional amplification came from the Pravda ecosystem and known pro-Kremlin influencers.

Outcome: TBD

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective: [T0139.001: Discourage](#) — undermine confidence in Moldova's institutions/elections via sustained narratives of external control and domestic "usurpation."

Objective: [T0135.004: Polarise](#) — accentuate pro-EU vs. pro-Russian cleavages through high-salience grievance frames and emotive visuals.

[T0130.002: Utilize Bulletproof Hosting](#) — Njalla registration, Cloudflare proxying, VK Cloud origin conceal true operators.

[T0049.007: Inauthentic Sites Amplify News and Narratives](#) — Pravda network rehosts/boosts REST content cross-language to widen reach.

[T0084.004: Appropriate Content](#) — EXIF paths ("C:\Rybar на C\REST\...") and shared assets show reuse/porting of Rybar materials into REST outputs.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: TBD

Recommendations: Preserve web/metadata evidence and maintain chain of custody; Alert X, Telegram, TikTok, Cloudflare and registrar to coordinated network behaviour for enforcement/geofencing; Notify Moldovan election/cyber authorities and EU bodies re: election-risk mitigation; Monitor/flag the Pravda network and Serbian-centred amplifiers; Increase platform detection of homoglyph/metadata fingerprints and coordinated infrastructure indicators; Conduct targeted media literacy outreach in Moldova ahead of key electoral milestones.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	FIMI Assessment
DFRLab , GLOBSEC	Russia	Evidence sheet	Jakub Kubś, GLOBSEC Eto Buziashvili, DFRLab	Web domains; X, Facebook, Instagram, Telegram accounts	High certainty